FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Since its invention nearly 3,000 years ago, the Greek alphabet has variously been deployed to denote different things: academic excellence, as in the Phi Beta Kappa Society; personality types, such as alpha males; even scientific phenomena, such as gamma rays. Only in May 2021 did it come to represent the multiple personalities of an organism that poses a severe threat to human existence. In an effort to dissociate any country with versions of the deadly virus, the World Health Organization chose to assign them letters of the Greek alphabet. Thus the world was introduced to the Alpha, Beta, Gamma, Delta and now the Omicron variants of the SARS-CoV-2 virus. Experts acknowledge Omicron as the fastest-spreading variant yet, which is responsible for the global resurgence of the pandemic, accounting for 1.7 million new cases daily. In India, it has spread at a speed four times than that of Delta during the second wave. Omicron accounted for 85 per cent of the positive cases in genomic studies of samples from across the country. The daily average of cases in India stood at 150,307 on January 12, and that number is expected to grow exponentially in the coming days.



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In what might seem reassuring, only some 5-10 per cent of the people infected during the current 'Omicron wave' have required hospitalisation, a quarter of the rate during the earlier 'Delta wave'. However, one credible model projects that India could see a peak of 1 million cases a day. This would mean a hospital bed requirement of 50,000 to 100,000 a day, going by the current hospitalisation rate for Covid patients. Given that an average patient requires seven days of hospitalisation, India could need 350,000 to 700,000 beds at its peak. While this is a manageable number in theory—India currently has 1.8 million isolation beds, 500,000 oxygen-supported beds and 140,000 ICU beds—there is no telling where the infection may surge and whether those areas will have adequate medical facilities. This could lead to localised shortages.

Despite being a variant of the original Covid-19 virus, now christened Alpha, Omicron has several unique features. It has 50 mutations overall, way more than Delta's 18. A significant number are on the spike protein that enables the virus to invade human cells. This makes it the most infectious variant of the coronavirus yet. It doesn't spare even those who are fully vaccinated or those who have previously been infected with the virus. A study at the University of Hong Kong suggests that Omicron is up to 70 times more transmissible than the Delta variant. It also has a shorter incubation period of three days, compared to four days for Delta and six days for Alpha. Its symptoms, too, are different. Unlike Delta, which often attacked the lower respiratory tract, Omicron replicates more in the throat and nose. According to a study by the CDC, US, the four most common symptoms of Omicron include cold, fatigue, nasal congestion and a runny nose.

However, while the disease caused by Omicron may appear relatively mild compared to Delta, WHO director-general Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus warns, "Omicron is not the common cold." That warning is vital for India, as many of us have dropped our guard against the virus, treating it as no more than the common flu. Yet, Omicron is capable of keeping a person bedridden for a week or more. The new strain can also prove fatal for the more vulnerable, such as the elderly or those with comorbidities. Experts also warn that the need for hospital beds could increase dramatically if the virus's spread is not effectively restricted. Apart from putting an enormous strain on the country's health infrastructure, it could seriously impact India's economic growth.

Our cover story, 'The Omicron Explosion: How Dangerous?', written by Senior Associate Editor Sonali Acharjee, examines the science behind the new strain—what distinguishes Omicron from previous strains, how to test and treat its symptoms, and what the new mutations mean for the future of the pandemic.

Deputy Editor Amarnath K. Menon looks at the efficacy of our current vaccines against Omicron and the potential of booster doses to halt the third wave. Executive Editor M.G. Arun and Deputy Editor Shwweta Punj analyse the economic impact of the renewed health crisis and what Budget 2022 can do to ensure economic revival is uninterrupted. Acharjee and her many colleagues at INDIA TODAY have now worked on 34 cover stories on Covid-19 since its outbreak in Wuhan in late 2019. "What is different in this wave is the extent of pandemic fatigue among the public," she says.

While experts believe that the virus is mutating towards endemicity—becoming more infectious over a shorter duration—it is still too soon to bid Covid-19 goodbye. Nor is Omicron likely to be the last of the Covid variants the world will see. Right now, it seems like a ferocious tsunami that may not last long and eventually pass. But how much damage it wreaks in this limited period remains the big unknown so far.

The best strategy remains masking up, testing, timely treatment, vaccination, and authentic information. At least, until such time as science can reveal more about where the pandemic is headed and how to stop it. Till then, stay safe.



(Aroon Purie)